THE LOWER MINNESOTA RIVER VALLEY · FIFTY YEARS, 1976–2026

Minnesota Valley
National Wildlife Refuge

FORT SNELLING TO HENDERSON · MNI SOTA WAKPA

Established by Congress on October 8, 1976, Minnesota Valley National Wildlife Refuge is part of a corridor of land and water stretching nearly 70 miles along the Minnesota River (Mni Sota Wakpa), from Bloomington to Henderson. Its more than 15,000 acres of marsh, floodplain lake, bottomland forest, oak savanna and prairie give migrating waterfowl, bald eagles and songbirds a haven at the edge of the Twin Cities. The valley is Dakota homeland; Bdote, where the Minnesota and Mississippi rivers meet, is a place of deep significance to the Dakota Oyate.

REFUGE UNITS

		acres
Long Meadow Lake	*Bloomington*	2,403
Black Dog Lake	*Burnsville*	1,500
Bloomington Ferry	*Bloomington*	437
Wilkie	*Shakopee, Savage*	2,037
Upgrala	*Eden Prairie, Chanhassen*	419
Chaska	*Carver, Chaska*	580
Rapids Lake	*Carver*	2,203
Louisville Swamp	*Jordan, Shakopee*	2,625
San Francisco	*Jordan, Carver*	52
St. Lawrence	*Jordan, Belle Plaine*	451
Jessenland	*Belle Plaine, Henderson*	1,127
Blakeley	*Henderson*	1,144
Round Lake	*Arden Hills (inset)*	157
Total		**15,135**

Includes fee-title, easement and cooperatively managed lands; acreages computed from USFWS unit data.

VISITOR CENTERS

Bloomington Education and Visitor Center
3815 American Blvd. East, Bloomington · 952-854-5900

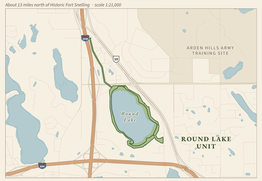
Rapids Lake Education and Visitor Center
15865 Rapids Lake Road, Carver · 952-361-4500

www.fws.gov/refuge/minnesota-valley

LOCATION

ROUND LAKE UNIT, ARDEN HILLS

About 13 miles north of Historic Fort Snelling · scale 1:21,000



LEGEND

- Refuge land owned by USFWS (fee title)
- Refuge easement or cooperative agreement
- Approved refuge acquisition boundary
- Valley floor, up to about 30 ft above the river
- River or lake
- Marsh or swamp
- Stream
- State park or recreation area
- Scientific and Natural Area or Wildlife Mgmt. Area
- Regional or county park
- Tribal land
- Airport grounds
- County boundary
- Refuge trail
- State trail
- Regional trail
- Interstate
- U.S. or state freeway
- U.S. or state highway
- County road
- Local road
- Railroad
- Visitor center
- Trailhead or parking
- Boat launch
- Historic site
- Point of interest
- Airport
- City or town under 5,000 people
- Interstate, U.S. and state routes

Scale 1:42,000 at 84 × 42 in · 1 inch ≈ about 0.66 mile (use the bars at other sizes)

0 1 2 3 4 5 miles
0 2 4 6 8 kilometers

N

Shaded relief from USGS 3DEP 10-meter elevation. The north arrow points to grid north, within 1 degree of true north on this map. UTM projection, zone 15 north, North American Datum of 1983.

Data sources: U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service refuge units and land status, approved acquisition boundary, trails and facilities (FWS cadastral and refuge-facilities data, 2020–2026); unit acreages are computed from these data. U.S. Geological Survey 3D Elevation Program 1/3 arc-second elevation (relief shading and valley-floor tint). National Hydrography Dataset, Geographic Names Information System. U.S. Census Bureau TIGER/Line Shapefiles 2026 (roads, rail, boundaries, cities, tribal lands, river surfaces); 2025 cartographic boundary files. Vintage 2025 population estimates. Minnesota Department of Natural Resources via the Minnesota Geospatial Commons: state parks, Scientific and Natural Areas, Wildlife Management Areas, state trails, lakes and wetlands. Metropolitan Council: regional parks, regional trails, airport boundaries. Minnesota Department of Transportation: airport runways. Dakota place names (Bdote, Mni Sota Wakpa, Wakpa Tanka, Oheyawahi): Minnesota Historical Society and National Park Service.

Boundaries are approximate and for general reference only. This is not an official U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service publication; check with the refuge for current regulations, trail conditions and seasonal closures. Map compiled October 2026.

FIFTY YEARS ON THE RIVER · 1976–2026

1976
Congress establishes the refuge on October 8 (Public Law 94-466), authorizing an initial purchase of 9,500 acres.

1984
A conservation plan is completed with the State of Minnesota and local partners; the Act is amended to add 2,000 acres.

1995
The Mittelstaat tract, today's Rapids Lake Unit, is added, bringing the refuge to nearly 14,000 acres.

2020
The refuge is designated an urban wildlife refuge and awarded $1 million to strengthen urban programs.

2026
The refuge marks 50 years with anniversary events. More than 45 miles of free trails are open daily, 5 a.m. to 10 p.m.